of these, at Sirhind, dragged on for almost forty days, with Humayun, Bairam and Abul Ma'ali leading battalions against Sikandar Suri – most daunting of the several Suris now fighting over Hindustan – and his army of 80,000 horsemen. 'The rush of arrows and the clash of swords / Tore the marrow of elephants and the gallbladders of tigers' – and there were some who lost heart at the very sight. Hamida's own brother Muazzam, for example, was so sure of defeat that he wrote to Sikandar Suri pledging his support to the Afghan.[71]

Muazzam did not realize that the luck of the Mughals had changed. Humayun won all his battles in Punjab, including Sirhind. He 'undid' the debacles that had propelled his clan from Hindustan, writes a modern historian, and 'sealed the fate of the Afghan empire of Sher Shah'.[72]

And yet, it seems, his victories brought little cheer to the reinstated padishah.

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Half a year after Sirhind, Humayun, seemingly well settled in Delhi, had begun to nurse morbid thoughts. If Abul Fazl is to be believed, it was difficult to get him to stop talking about his imminent demise; indeed, he 'took pleasure in speaking on the subject'. At one point, Humayun told Akbar and his courtiers of his 'inevitable doom', and consoled them. He liked to tell the story of a man who was inspired to die by the cemetery of Ghazni, declaring he felt the same upon seeing Delhi's shrines. Another time, a voice spoke to him after his dawn prayers, reciting a quatrain that began, 'O God, make me wholly Thine.'

Tears flowed from Humayun's eyes as he recited the poem. Later, he would inscribe another bit of melancholy verse upon an arch in his Delhi fort: 'I've heard that on this gilded dome [the sky] 'tis writ / The end of all things is praiseworthy.'[73]

Finally, to hammer home the point, Humayun put seven days' supply of opium on a piece of paper and announced: 'This is all the opium we shall eat.'

On the seventh day, a Friday in late January 1556, Humayun called for rose water and swallowed the last of his opium – there were four pellets remaining – and had an unexceptional day. In the late afternoon, he received